raise

Design Notes: Decisions, Colour and Type

These are the design decisions behind Raise, in four parts: the choices that reduce embarrassment and make starting feel smaller, why Raise is purple and yellow, the colour and type rules, and a contrast check on the palette. Every decision has a cost, and I state it, because a design team should know what each choice gives up. Numbers come from my research: 28 parents and 15 teenagers on my form, and 31 interviews.

1. Decisions that reduce embarrassment and make starting feel smaller

1. No account, no name, no email. Every field is a reason to leave. The top worries parents named about a tool like this were the privacy of what they type (39%) and their child finding out and feeling managed (29%). She can start without giving anything away, and the privacy line is on the first screen. *Cost:* I cannot follow a parent across devices, her saved plans are lost if she clears her browser, and I cannot send reminders.

2. Ask “have you tried before?” first, on every topic, with one tap. 5 of 28 parents had tried and it went badly, and the top thing that would help any parent start was knowing how their teenager might react (10 of 28). One tap tells the plan which parent it is writing for. *Cost:* it adds a step before she gets anything, so it can lose parents. I measure it with an intake completion target of 90%, and if it falls under 75% I shorten the questions.

3. Name the feeling on screen. The chips say “Nervous”, “Embarrassed”, “Not sure what to say”. 13 of 28 parents named fear of saying it wrong, embarrassment, or never having had this talk with their own parents. Seeing the words tells her she is not the only one, without a lecture about it. *Cost:* some parents will not want to tap a feeling. It is optional and can be skipped.

4. The words stay hers. The opener is an editable text box labelled “edit these words to sound like you”, with three styles to swap between. 32% of parents feared saying too much or too little and 25% did not know what to say. A sentence she has changed is one she can say. *Cost:* she can edit it into something worse and I cannot see it. I count how often she edits it, and I read the reflections for what she actually said.

5. At most three likely reactions, each tentative. A parent who is afraid does not need a list of everything that could go wrong. Three reactions with a short way to respond answer the fear of “what if they say…”, and the rest sit in the FAQs. Every reading starts “one possibility is…”. *Cost:* the reaction she meets may not be one of the three. The FAQs cover more, and the hedged wording reads as less sure.

6. A way out inside the plan, and a way back after it. Fear of making it worse is the top blocker (32%), and teenagers named a bad time (33%) and lecturing (20%) as why they shut down. One of the likely reactions is “not now”, with a line she can use to stop without a fight. A card called “After you talk” tells her to come back and tap “How it went”, so the plan is something she uses and returns to, not something she saves and forgets. *Cost:* a parent can use “not now” to avoid the conversation altogether. The north star counts only specific accounts of what happened, so pausing is not counted as a completed conversation.

7. Play her answers back at the top of the plan. “You told me: tried once, they got irritated, you feel embarrassed.” It shows the plan was written for her and gives her a way back if it was not. *Cost:* one more line of height on a short screen.

8. One primary action per screen, and it is the only yellow. Choosing a topic, preparing the plan and saving the plan are each the single obvious thing to do. Secondary actions (try another approach, the optional intention) are quiet links and chips. *Cost:* the secondary actions can be missed, so a parent may not know she can ask for another approach. I watch how often it is used.

9. Honest labels. After saving, the app says “Plan saved”. It never says “done” or “completed”. Saving a plan is not the same as having the conversation, and a label that says otherwise would count the wrong thing. *Cost:* no sense of reward for saving, which may weaken her reason to come back.

10. No streaks, no reminders, no points in v1. A conversation is not a daily act, and a streak turns a hard talk into a chore. A reminder needs a phone number or email, and I do not want to collect either. *Cost:* nothing pulls her back apart from the message I send by hand within a day. This is the biggest risk to the north star, and the one I watch hardest.

11. Neutral topic names and the over-the-shoulder test. “Stress and low mood”, not a diagnosis. If her teenager read any screen over her shoulder, nothing on it would hurt them. *Cost:* neutral names are less specific, so a parent has to read the description to choose.

12. A calm safety response. When wording describes danger, the screen is steady and plain, not alarmed. It takes what she wrote seriously and shows the helplines (Childline 1098, Tele-MANAS 14416, the cyber crime helpline 1930, and 112) so each number can be tapped to call. *Cost:* a quieter screen carries less urgency than an alarm-style one. The numbers are large and the first line says plainly that this is beyond what a conversation plan can do.

13. Speak or type on the same screen. Many parents speak at length and type little, and a long typed account of a hard moment is hard work. Voice sits next to the text box, the transcript stays editable, and a plain line says audio is not saved by Raise. The mic is also the only place a language is chosen. The rest of the app is in English, because all 28 parents on my form chose English and this first version is for parents comfortable with an English app. That form was in English and reached English-comfortable groups, so I read it as who I reached, not what every parent prefers. *Cost:* parents who are more comfortable in Tamil or Hindi get the plan in English. It depends on the browser’s speech support and mis-hears Tamil and Hindi more often. The browser’s own speech service may process the audio, so the screen says so. Typing always works.

14. Ask how it went with one tap, and feedback last. Describing a hard conversation is the biggest ask in the app, and 18% of the parents I spoke to had tried and it went badly. So she first taps one of five outcomes, including “They weren’t ready” and “I haven’t talked yet”, which has no deadline. A stall sits beside success, not below it. What she sees next depends on the tap: follow-up lines she can use today, and a choice to rebuild the plan another way, try the same plan on another day, or come back later. The four feedback questions come only after that, and “Skip for now” is always there. *Cost:* an extra step before the feedback form, so fewer parents may reach the four questions. The outcome is saved on its own, so I still learn whether she attempted it.

2. Why Raise is purple and yellow

My direction. I chose purple because it represents healing. A parent who opens Raise is often tired, embarrassed or worried. I want the first thing she sees to steady her and to build her confidence, not to warn her or sell to her. Yellow is the encouragement: the one place we ask her to act.

Why the pairing works for a parent.

- **Purple** sits between energy and calm. It is associated with calm and focus, harmony and balance, and a trustworthy, considered feel (Sensational Color). That is the register I want for a conversation she is dreading: serious, but not cold or clinical. Soft lavender backgrounds carry the calm across the whole screen.

- **Yellow** is associated with optimism, warmth and friendliness, and it is highly visible (Sensational Color). That makes it the right colour for the one button we want her to tap. Large areas of bright yellow can feel restless, so I use it only for the primary action and a small pale-yellow highlight, never as a background for a block of text.
- **Together**, purple and yellow are far apart on the colour wheel, so the yellow button stands out against the calm purple page without any need for red or an alarm tone.

What I do not use. No red, no warning icons, and no competing accent colours (blue, cyan, green or orange) anywhere in a plan. Nothing in a plan should feel like a scolding.

Where each colour goes

Colour	Role
Primary purple	The brand: selected states, key surfaces, links
Sunshine yellow	The one primary action on each screen
Soft lavender	The page background, to keep the screen calm
White	Cards and navigation
Light lavender	Topic chips and soft sections
Deep purple	Headings and body text
Muted purple	Supporting text and borders
Soft violet	Decoration only (blossoms, small accents)
Pale yellow	Small highlights, such as the edge of the “After you talk” card

3. Tokens, type and usage rules

These are the values the app already uses, from its design tokens file.

Token	Hex	Used for
Primary purple `--color-primary`	`#6C4DF6`	Primary brand colour, selected states, links
Sunshine yellow `--color-secondary`	`#FFD93D`	Primary action background
Soft lavender `--color-background`	`#F7F4FF`	Page background
White `--color-surface`	`#FFFFFF`	Cards, navigation
Light lavender `--color-lavender`	`#E8E2FF`	Chips, soft sections
Deep purple `--color-text`	`#24185A`	Headings, body text, text on yellow
Muted purple `--color-text-muted`	`#5E5490`	Supporting text, borders
Soft violet `--color-violet-soft`	`#9A89FF`	Decoration
Pale yellow `--color-yellow-soft`	`#FFE680`	Small highlights

Type. The app uses the system sans-serif stack (Arial and Helvetica), with Noto Sans Tamil and Noto Sans Devanagari for Tamil and Hindi. No web font is downloaded, which keeps the first load light on mobile data. The design tokens file still names Geist Sans, so it should be changed to match the app. The sizes below come from that file.

Style	Mobile	Weight
Page heading	30 to 36 px	600
Section heading	22 to 26 px	600
Body	16 px, line height 1.6	400
Supporting text	14 px	400

Shape and spacing. Spacing in steps of 4 px. Cards have a 24 px radius and controls a 14 px radius. Mobile page gutter is 20 px. Design mobile-first and then adapt for desktop. Avoid horizontal overflow and keep comfortable tap targets of at least 44 × 44 px.

Usage rules

- Soft lavender is the page background. Use large purple surfaces only for a strong brand moment.
- The primary action is sunshine yellow with deep purple text. Keep one obvious primary action per screen.
- Use white or light text on purple. Never put white text on yellow.
- Headings and body copy are deep purple. Supporting text is muted purple.
- Reference tokens. Do not add hard-coded colours. Any new colour must be documented and approved before use.
- Do not rely on colour alone to show a selection, an error or completion. Pair it with text, a tick or a shape.
- Do not repeat the Raise wordmark prominently more than once on a screen.
- Keep rounded controls consistent, and give every control a visible focus state.
- Blossoms are one reusable asset. Keep them away from important text, do not put one on every card, and never let a blossom suggest a conversation must happen.

4. Contrast check on the app’s palette

I calculated the contrast ratio for each pairing the three key screens use, using the WCAG formula. The standard I design to is WCAG 2.2 AA: 4.5:1 for normal text, 3:1 for large text and for the borders and parts of controls that show what they are.

Pairing	Where	Ratio	Result
Deep purple on soft lavender	Headings and body on the page	14.3:1	Passes
Deep purple on white	Text on cards	15.5:1	Passes
Deep purple on sunshine yellow	The primary button label	11.3:1	Passes
Deep purple on pale yellow	Highlights	12.5:1	Passes
Deep purple on light lavender	Text on chips	12.4:1	Passes
Muted purple on white	Supporting text on cards	6.7:1	Passes

Pairing	Where	Ratio	Result
Muted purple on soft lavender	Supporting text on the page	6.2:1	Passes
Muted purple on light lavender	Supporting text on chips	5.3:1	Passes
White on primary purple	Selected chips, purple surfaces	5.2:1	Passes
Primary purple on white	Links, text on cards	5.2:1	Passes
Primary purple on soft lavender	Links on the page	4.8:1	Passes
Yellow on primary purple	Accent text on purple	3.8:1	Large text only
White on sunshine yellow		1.4:1	**Fails.** Never use
Primary purple on light lavender	Small text on chips	4.2:1	**Fails for small text**
Soft violet on white	Borders on inputs and chips	2.8:1	**Fails** for borders (needs 3:1)
Soft violet on soft lavender	Borders on the page, and the app's focus ring	2.6:1	**Fails** for borders and focus rings (needs 3:1)
Border `#CFC4FF` on white	The app's concern box, cards, secondary buttons	1.6:1	**Fails** for input and button borders
Border `#CFC4FF` on soft lavender	Cards and secondary buttons on the page	1.5:1	**Fails** for input and button borders
White on soft violet		2.8:1	**Fails.** Never use

What I will change because of this.

1. **Borders on inputs, chips and secondary buttons use muted purple.** The built app draws the concern box and the secondary buttons with a `#CFC4FF` border (1.5 to 1.6:1), and soft violet is 2.6 to 2.8:1. Both are too faint to show where a control is. Muted purple is 6.2 to 6.7:1. Those lighter colours stay for decoration and card edges. The wireframes already use muted purple.
2. **Text on light lavender chips is deep purple.** Primary purple on light lavender is 4.2:1, which is under 4.5:1 for small text. Primary purple stays for links and text on white or soft lavender, where it passes.
3. **The focus ring is primary purple, not soft violet.** The app's global focus outline is 3 px soft violet, which is 2.6:1 on the page background. Primary purple is 4.8:1. Six buttons also set a white focus outline in their classes, so I will check that none of them sits on a light background.
4. **The yellow button is identified by its label and shape**, not by its edge against the page (1.3:1). Its label passes at 11.3:1.

I will recheck contrast in the built app on a real phone, because screens and compression change how colours look. The checks I will run are contrast on the rendered screens, 200% zoom with no horizontal scroll, tap targets of at least 44 px, visible keyboard focus, and no meaning carried by colour alone.

Sources: Sensational Color: purple · Sensational Color: yellow · Raise design tokens and colour guide · WCAG 2.2 contrast formula.